

Overview Of The Text

Welcome!

Welcome to the lecture notes for SOC 105 at Stony Brook University! My name is Nick Wilson, and I've been teaching this course here since the Fall of 2016. Until now, I employed a regular textbook, but this semester have decided to transition to these typed lecture notes.

Why These Notes?

Over the course of teaching introduction to sociology (with enrollments of around 250 students), I've grown increasingly dissatisfied with the textbook I was using, and, indeed, any one that I could find. This was for several reasons.

Cost. Most textbooks seem unjustifiably expensive today. A quick glance at Amazon shows that they can range from \$30 to over \$150 to buy, and still a substantial amount of money to rent.

Quality. While most textbooks are nominally written by well-known academics, as we will see, sociology is a notoriously difficult subject to even introduce, so the quality of textbooks varies wildly, both within and among the different offerings.

Voice. You will find that I prefer to write prose in a direct, conversational, active style, and this is something that is surprisingly hard to find in a textbook. Even ones that are written

Formally, I am an Associate Professor of Sociology at Stony Brook University, but I don't particularly like such trappings, especially in person, so please just call me "Nick." Note, however, that many of your professors want to be addressed formally!

“simply” tend to overdo the passive voice, pointlessly elevate jargon, exaggerate the unity and certainty of sociology’s findings, and employ other false trappings of scientific authority.¹

Datedness. Because traditional textbooks take so long to conceive, write, vet, and physically produce, they are usually surprisingly dated by the time they are published.²

Intellectual divergence. Finally, I also noticed that I increasingly disagreed with most available textbooks. I especially chafed at them oversimplifying sociology. In my view, the field is ambiguous, difficult, and challenging; indeed, it is one of the hardest sciences to practice, because it has the most complex object of study—society itself. By extension, I have come to believe that an introduction to sociology should be clear, but not simple.

With those reasons in mind, beginning in the summer of 2024 I decided to transform and extend my lecture slides into these notes, and I worked intensively to complete the first draft of these notes in the summer of 2026.

Organization of These Notes

After this Introduction, the notes are divided into four main parts.

Part I: Orientation

In Part I, I discuss sociology’s distinctive intellectual style and heritage,³ its place among other disciplines,⁴ and then its (several) methods and their benefits and challenges of each.⁵

Part II: Conceptual Foundation

After that, since this a course meant to introduce you to the field, the bulk of the notes, comprising six chapters, is in Part II, which outlines what I consider to be the fundamental conceptual building blocks in sociology. I think sociology is fundamentally

¹ I think I am most influenced by the writing styles of George Orwell (in “Politics and the English Language”), Christopher Lasch (in *Plain Style*), and Strunk and White’s *Elements of Style*.

² For instance, it is only now that textbooks are even acknowledging, much less considering the impact of, COVID-19.

³ Chapter 1: [Imagination](#).

⁴ Chapter 2: [Discipline](#).

⁵ Chapter 3: [Methods](#).

oriented around the intersection of meaning and action,⁶ especially in contexts of interaction,⁷ is usually organized following social structures,⁸ the result of which are qualities we have usually called identities or selves.⁹ Finally, there are two special characteristics of social structures that are such common features of sociological analysis that they have become foundational: that your place in social structures is not what it is only because of everyone's agreement, but also because of power and discipline;¹⁰ and that, especially in complex societies, almost every social structure exhibits some form of inequality.¹¹

⁶ Chapter 4: [Meaning and Action](#).

⁷ Chapter 5: [Interaction](#).

⁸ Chapter 6: [Social Structure](#).

⁹ Chapter 7: [Identity](#).

¹⁰ Chapter 8: [Power and Discipline](#).

¹¹ Chapter 9: [Inequality](#).

Part III: Elaborations

Part III combines these building blocks, along with the two world-historical shifts of central interest to sociologists (the emergence and eventual dominance of capitalism and the rise, transformation, and dissolution of large empires) to understand key features of the era in which we live, “modernity.” The forces at work in this era are different from what came before in critical ways, and affect everything from our identities—our sense of race and ethnicity,¹² gender and sexuality,¹³ and even how we imagine our place in the world¹⁴—and has decisively reorganized our lives through political,¹⁵ economic,¹⁶ environmental,¹⁷ and even biological¹⁸ change.

¹² Chapter 10: [Race and Ethnicity](#).

¹³ Chapter 11: [Gender and Sexuality](#).

¹⁴ Chapter 12: [Globalization](#).

¹⁵ Chapter 13: [Politics](#).

¹⁶ Chapter 14: [Economics](#).

¹⁷ Chapter 15: [Environment](#).

¹⁸ Chapter 16: [Health](#).

How to Read this Text

Explain the best way to read the notes, focusing on (1) how I test, and (2) how that affects interacting with the notes relative to lecture and supplementary materials.

How to read these notes

How I test

Consequences of how I test for how to read these notes

Excursus on plain style in sociology

One recurring theme in these notes regards the intellectual status of sociology; briefly, is it a science or not? My position can be summarized as “of course sociology is a science, but we also need to expand our naive views of what a ‘science’ is.” Sociology strives to reveal what is true about the world, while also recognizing that the world is full of different phenomena that require different methods and approaches for us to know them adequately.

One consequence of this position about the nature of sociology is that there are radically different ways to express it. At one extreme, you can find sociologists who wish that the social world could be expressed in a neat series of equations

This position stands opposed to another view, which also affirms sociology’s status as a science.

You can either express yourself in a radically-positivist way, with equations, or in a radically-hermeneutic way, with obtuse prose. In between, however, is a style that is well-suited to connecting facts of different kinds and insight from different places: something like a “plain style” of sociological writing.